Source: Narad Index, Nalin Mehta and Rishabh Srivastava; for more details see Appendix 4/online on nalinmehta.in

Clearly, the BJP was betting that a lot more people were voting for it because of Modi and his charisma. Modi mentions grew by over 100 per cent between 2014 and 2019, while Congress mentions grew by 82.6 per cent. Anti-Congress-ism and the Modi factor became synonymous with the BJP discourse, with the prime minister held up as the personification of everything the Congress was not.

The Modi cult has been central to the rise of the BJP since 2014. It is also very unusual for the party. When L.K. Advani was leading the party in 2009, its communication was not as dominated by messaging about a great leader. Advani was the man who had single-handedly built the BJP into a political force, who had spearheaded the Ram Janmabhoomi movement and turned the party into a national force. Yet, in 2009, mentions of him were fourth highest of all topics, unlike Modi's dominance in 2019.

Furthermore, the volume of Modi mentions (0.661) in 2019 was three times that of Advani mentions (0.208) in 2009.

Figure 6.6: Modi 3x of Advani in BJP Outreach: A Comparison of its Prime-ministerial Candidates in Election Years (2009, 2019)